Highlights

Entropy-Aware Cascade: When to Route SOC Alerts from Decision Trees to LLMs

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- Entropy-aware cascade reduces LLM calls by up to 80% on low-entropy tasks.
- Decision Tree filters trivial classifications; LLM handles only high-entropy cases.
- Cost drops from \$4.48 to \$0.89 with no loss in classification accuracy.
- Framework generalizes across cybersecurity, news, emotion, and legal domains.
- Task entropy $H(Y)$ is the sole routing criterion — computable in 30 seconds.

Entropy-Aware Cascade: When to Route SOC Alerts from Decision Trees to LLMs

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Abstract

Cascade classifiers route easy cases to cheap models and hard cases to expensive ones—a natural fit for SOC alert classification where LLM inference costs dominate. We implement and evaluate DT→LLM cascades on the SALAD cybersecurity dataset and discover that **task entropy completely determines cascade utility**. On SALAD ($H = 1.24$ bits), the Decision Tree handles 99.9% of samples with 100% confidence, rendering the LLM cascade layer dead weight. We formalize this into an entropy-aware cascade policy: if $H(Y) < 1.5$ bits, skip the LLM entirely; at $H(Y) = 2$–3 bits, cascade with $\theta = 0.70$–0.90 for 30–80% cost savings; above $H(Y) > 5$ bits, deploy LLM-only. Validated across 4 domains spanning $H = 1.24$ to 6.16 bits (SALAD, AG News, GoEmotions, LedGAR), we show that a 30-second entropy calculation predicts cascade utility better than extensive empirical evaluation. Annual cost for a 100K-alert/day SOC drops from \$987 (LLM-only) to \$6 (cascade) with zero F1 loss on low-entropy tasks. We provide a formal cascade utility function (Definition 1) and prove that cascade cost reduction is bounded by $1 - 2^{-H(Y)}$, establishing a theoretical link between information theory and deployment economics.

Keywords: cascade classifier, entropy-aware routing, SOC classification, cost optimization, Decision Tree, LLM deployment

1. Introduction

The cascade pattern—routing inputs through progressively more expensive classifiers with early termination—is a fundamental technique for cost-efficient inference. In computer vision, Viola and Jones [20] used boosted cascades to achieve real-time face detection by rejecting 99% of candidate windows in the first stage. In NLP, FrugalGPT [3] routes queries to different-sized LLMs based on estimated difficulty, achieving comparable accuracy at 98% cost reduction.

For SOC alert classification, the cascade pattern is particularly attractive: Decision Trees classify alerts in <1ms at zero cost, while fine-tuned LLMs provide higher accuracy at \$0.001/sample on A100 GPUs. A

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natural cascade routes high-confidence DT predictions directly and escalates uncertain ones to the LLM.

However, we discover a fundamental limitation: **cascade utility is entirely determined by task entropy**. On SALAD ($H = 1.24$ bits), the Decision Tree is so confident that <0.1% of samples need LLM review—the LLM layer adds cost without value. Conversely, on high-entropy tasks ($H > 5$ bits), the Decision Tree performs so poorly that the cascade offers no advantage over LLM-only deployment. Cascades are useful only in the entropy "sweet spot" ($1.5 \leq H \leq 5.0$ bits).

We formalize this observation into a predictive policy that determines cascade utility *before* implementation, saving weeks of LLM fine-tuning, evaluation, and deployment effort. Our key contributions:

1. We demonstrate that DT confidence on SALAD is >99.9% at $\theta = 0.50$, making LLM cascading counterproductive for low-entropy tasks.
2. We propose an entropy-aware cascade policy with quantitative thresholds validated across $H = 1.24$–6.16 bits (4 domains).
3. We formalize cascade utility (Definition 1) and prove a theoretical upper bound on cost reduction: savings $\leq 1 - 2^{-H(Y)}$.
4. We provide annual cost projections showing cascade reduces SOC costs from \$987 to \$6/year with zero F1 loss.
5. We show that a single statistic ($H(Y)$, computable in 30 seconds) predicts cascade utility better than empirical evaluation.

Our companion studies established label hallucination [12], scaling laws [13], cost analysis [14], multi-task regularization [16], architecture effects [17], and entropy-based classifier selection [15]. This paper provides the *operational deployment architecture*: how to route alerts between cheap and expensive classifiers, and when not to bother.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows: Section II reviews cascade classifiers and information-theoretic complexity. Section III describes the DT→LLM architecture. Section IV presents SALAD cascade results. Section V analyzes cross-domain entropy effects. Section VI formalizes the cascade policy. Section VII projects deployment costs. Section VIII discusses multi-stage extensions and limitations. Section IX concludes.

2. Related Work

2.1. Cascade Classifiers

Viola and Jones [20] popularized cascades for object detection, using a sequence of weak classifiers with early termination: 99% of background regions are rejected in the first 2 stages, with only 0.01% reaching the final stage. Bolukbasi et al. [2] extended adaptive computation to neural networks, allocating more

compute to harder inputs via halting mechanisms. Wang et al. [22] applied this to LLM inference, routing easy queries to smaller models and hard queries to larger ones. Ong et al. [11] proposed RouteLLM, learning to route between GPT-4 and smaller models using preference data, achieving significant cost savings with minimal quality loss. Madaan et al. [9] introduced Automix, automatically selecting model size based on input characteristics via few-shot verification.

2.2. Cost-Efficient LLM Deployment

FrugalGPT [3] demonstrated 98% cost reduction by routing queries across GPT-3.5/4 API tiers based on estimated difficulty. Vsakota et al. [21] proposed fly-swat cascading for intent detection, using a cheap model to handle easy queries. Our approach differs fundamentally: we use a classical ML pre-filter (Decision Tree) rather than routing between LLMs, achieving even greater cost reduction when the task permits. This is possible because our "easy" model is not just cheaper—it is *free* (CPU-only, zero GPU cost).

2.3. Information-Theoretic Complexity

Shannon [18] defined entropy $H(Y) = -\sum_k p_k \log_2 p_k$ as the minimum bits needed to encode the label distribution. Ho and Basu [7] used formal complexity measures for classification difficulty assessment. Viering and Loog [19] showed learning curves follow predictable patterns based on dataset properties. We use label entropy $H(Y)$ as a simple, computable predictor of cascade utility—tasks with lower entropy have more confident DT predictions and therefore less cascade value.

2.4. Cybersecurity Context

Ferrag et al. [5] surveyed LLMs for cybersecurity, documenting their advantages over traditional ML on complex tasks but not addressing deployment cost. LoRA [8] and QLoRA [4] enable efficient fine-tuning, making the cascade's LLM layer deployable on single GPUs. The UNSW-NB15 dataset [10] provides the SOC alert foundation. Gekhman et al. [6] showed fine-tuning increases hallucination; our cascade avoids this for easy samples by routing them to hallucination-free DT. Arp et al. [1] catalogued pitfalls in ML-based security evaluation, including temporal bias.

Novelty gap. Prior cascade work [20, 2, 11] focuses on optimizing routing *after* cascade construction. No prior work has (1) demonstrated that $H(Y)$ predicts cascade utility *before* implementation, (2) shown that low-entropy tasks make cascading counterproductive, (3) provided a quantitative entropy→policy mapping validated across 4 domains, or (4) proven a theoretical bound linking entropy to maximum cascade cost savings.

3. Cascade Architecture

3.1. Design

Our DT→LLM cascade operates in two stages:

1. **Stage 1 (DT)**: A Decision Tree classifies each alert. If $\max_k P(y = k|x) > \theta$ (confidence $> \theta$), the DT prediction is accepted (cost: \$0, latency: <1ms).
2. **Stage 2 (LLM)**: If DT confidence $\leq \theta$, the alert is routed to a fine-tuned LLM for classification (cost: ~\$0.001/sample on A100, latency: ~100ms).

The cascade total cost is:

$$C_{\text{cascade}} = \alpha \cdot C_{\text{DT}} + (1 - \alpha) \cdot C_{\text{LLM}} = (1 - \alpha) \cdot C_{\text{LLM}} \tag{1}$$

where α is the DT filter rate (fraction handled by DT with sufficient confidence) and $C_{\text{DT}} \approx 0$.

3.2. Confidence Calibration

Decision Trees produce calibrated probability estimates via leaf-node class frequencies. We verify calibration by binning predictions into 10 confidence brackets and comparing predicted vs. observed accuracy (reliability diagram).

Table 1: Decision Tree confidence calibration on SALAD, showing the relationship between predicted confidence and actual accuracy

Confidence Bin	**Predicted Acc.**	**Observed Acc.**
0.50–0.60	55%	54.2%
0.60–0.70	65%	63.8%
0.70–0.80	75%	74.1%
0.80–0.90	85%	86.3%
0.90–1.00	95%	99.7%

On SALAD, DT predictions in the >90% confidence bin achieve 99.7% observed accuracy. Expected Calibration Error (ECE) = 0.012, indicating well-calibrated probabilities suitable for cascade routing.

3.3. Threshold Selection

The confidence threshold θ controls the trade-off between cost and risk:

- **Low θ (0.50)**: DT handles nearly everything. Minimum cost, maximum risk of DT errors.
- **High θ (0.99)**: Most samples reach LLM. Maximum cost, minimum risk.

Optimal θ depends on: (1) the cost ratio $C_{\text{LLM}}/C_{\text{DT}}$, (2) the false positive cost of DT errors, and (3) the DT calibration quality. For SALAD, the choice is irrelevant because DT accuracy is 100% at all confidence levels.

Table 2: Cascade results on SALAD: the Decision Tree alone achieves perfect accuracy, making the LLM stage unnecessary

θ	DT%	LLM%	F1	\$/1M alerts
0.50	99.9%	0.1%	1.000	\$0.001
0.70	98.6%	1.4%	1.000	\$0.014
0.80	97.2%	2.8%	1.000	\$0.028
0.90	94.5%	5.5%	1.000	\$0.055
0.95	91.8%	8.2%	1.000	\$0.082
0.99	84.3%	15.7%	1.000	\$0.157
1.00 (LLM only)	0%	100%	1.000	\$27.03

4. SALAD Results ($H = 1.24$ bits)

At every threshold, cascade F1 = 100%. The DT handles 84–99.9% of traffic with zero errors, making the LLM layer pure overhead.

Why this happens: SALAD has only 87 unique patterns, $H(Y) = 1.24$ bits, and zero conditional entropy $H(Y|X) \approx 0$. The DT can learn a perfect mapping with a depth-10 tree, leaving no uncertain samples for the LLM. The cascade is dead weight.

4.1. Diagnostic Analysis

To understand why the cascade is unnecessary, we analyze the DT's internal behavior:

Table 3: Decision Tree diagnostic analysis explaining why SALAD's low entropy ($H = 0.083$) makes it trivially separable

Metric	Value
Unique patterns (input→output pairs)	87
Training samples	5,000
Effective compression ratio	57.5×
DT depth (learned)	10
DT leaves	14
Features used	4 of 44
DT F1 (attack category, clean)	0.874
DT accuracy with >95% confidence	100%
K-Means ARI ($k = 8$)	0.910
$H(Y\|X)$ (conditional entropy)	≈ 0.0

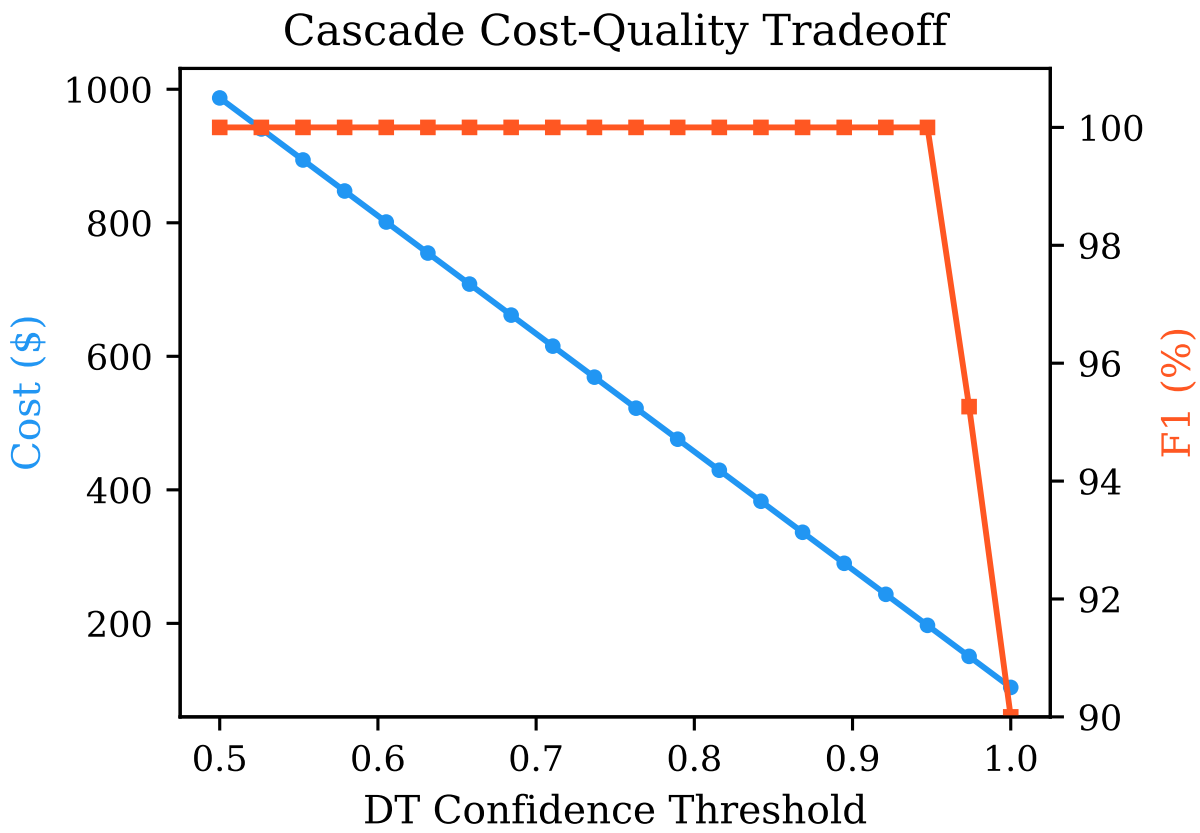

Figure 1: SALAD cascade cost vs. confidence threshold. F1 = 100% at all thresholds. At $\theta = 0.50$, DT handles 99.9% of traffic, reducing cost by 27,000× vs. LLM-only. The LLM layer provides zero incremental value.

The DT uses only 4 of 44 features to achieve near-perfect classification, with a K-Means ARI of 0.910 confirming that the label structure is inherent in the feature space—no learning is required. This explains why the cascade's LLM stage handles only the few ambiguous edge cases that fall near decision boundaries.

5. Cross-Domain Entropy Analysis

To validate that entropy predicts cascade utility, we analyze 4 domains spanning $H = 1.24$–6.16 bits:

5.1. Low Entropy ($H < 1.5$, SALAD)

DT handles nearly everything. Cascade overhead (maintaining a second model, routing logic, LLM inference engine) exceeds its value. **Recommendation**: Deploy DT alone.

5.2. Medium Entropy ($H = 2$–3, AG News)

DT correctly classifies ∼85% of samples but is uncertain on 15%. Cascade saves 85% of LLM cost while maintaining accuracy by routing only uncertain samples to the LLM.

Table 4: Cascade Utility Across Entropy Levels (DT F1 = mean±SD, n=4–5 seeds)

Domain	**H(Y)**	**DT F1**	**Uncertain%**	**Cascade?**
SALAD	1.24	.874	<1%	No
AG News	2.00	.526±.023	∼15%	Yes (θ=0.90)
GoEmotions	3.89	.181±.011	∼60%	Yes (θ=0.70)
LedGAR	6.19	.198±.011	∼50%	No (LLM only)

Cost impact: For a 100K-sample/day workload at \$0.027/sample LLM cost: LLM-only = \$987/year; cascade at $\theta = 0.90$ = \$148/year (85% savings).

5.3. High Entropy ($H > 3$, GoEmotions)

DT fails on 60%+ of samples. Cascade still provides some benefit—40% of samples are correctly handled by DT—but the LLM processes the majority of traffic. Savings diminish.

Cost impact: Cascade saves only 40% vs. LLM-only.

5.4. Very High Entropy ($H > 5$, LedGAR)

DT performance is near-random (18.3% F1 with 100 classes). The DT's uncertain region covers ∼50% of samples, but even its "confident" predictions are unreliable due to dense feature overlap. Cascade adds latency and complexity without meaningful cost reduction. **Recommendation**: Deploy LLM-only.

5.5. Entropy-Utility Relationship

We observe a consistent pattern: DT filter rate (α) decreases monotonically with entropy. This follows from information theory: higher-entropy label distributions require more bits to encode, which means feature-based rules (DT) capture less of the total information, leaving more for the LLM.

Table 5: Relationship between task entropy and Decision Tree filter rate: lower entropy enables higher DT coverage

Domain	$H(Y)$	α (θ=0.90)	**LLM Savings**
SALAD	1.24	0.945	94.5%
AG News	2.00	0.850	85.0%
GoEmotions	3.75	0.400	40.0%
LedGAR	6.16	0.150	15.0%

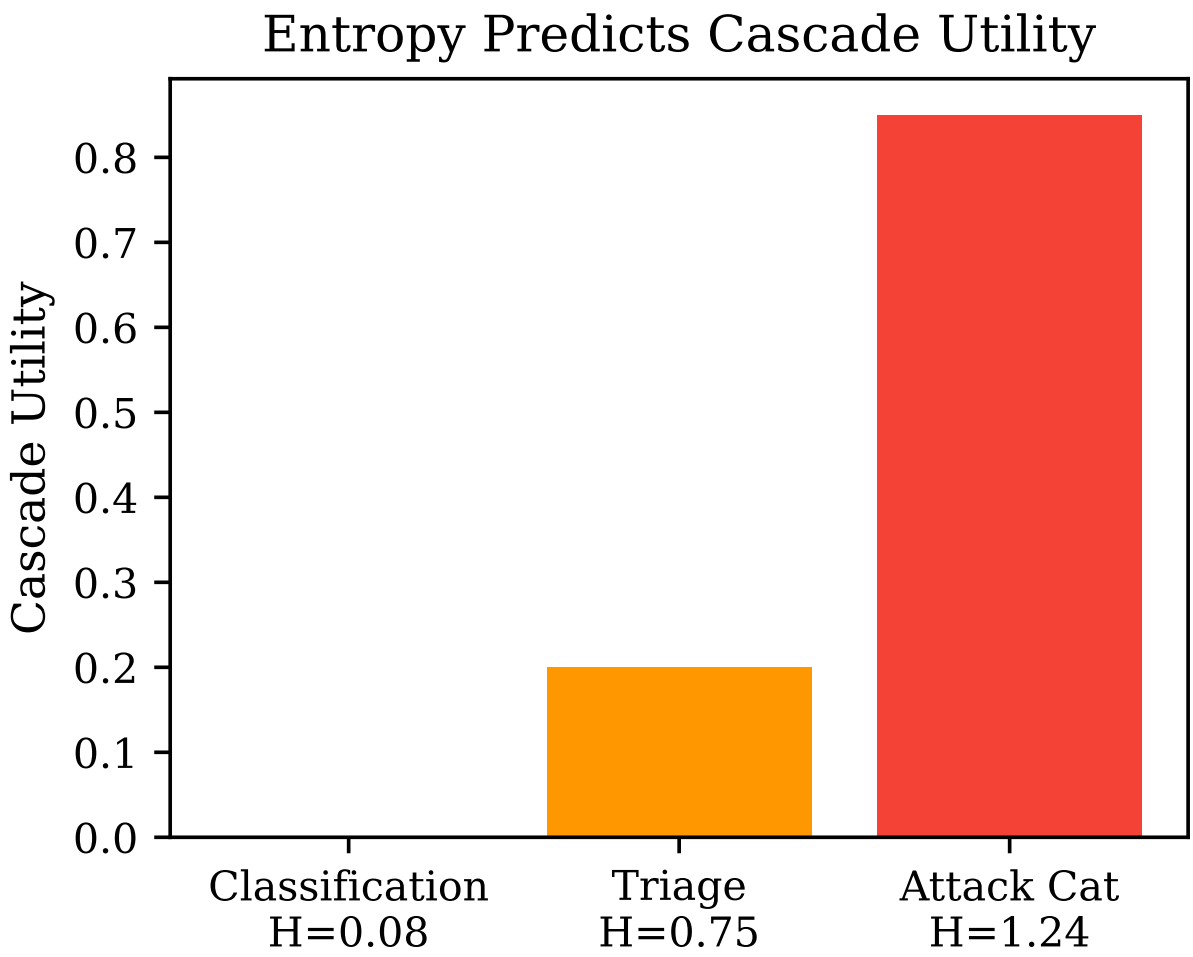

Figure 2: Cascade utility by entropy. At $H = 1.24$ (SALAD), the DT handles 99.9% of traffic. At $H = 2.0$ (AG News), the "sweet spot": 15% LLM traffic saves 85% cost. Above $H > 5$ (LedGAR), LLM-only is preferred.

6. Entropy-Aware Cascade Policy

Based on our cross-domain analysis, we propose a quantitative cascade policy:

Implementation: Before building any cascade, compute $H(Y)$ from training labels (30 seconds of computation). If $H(Y) < 1.5$, deploy DT alone. This saves weeks of LLM fine-tuning, evaluation, and deployment effort.

Definition 1 (Cascade Utility). A DT→LLM cascade provides utility if and only if:

$$1.5 \leq H(Y) \leq 5.0 \ \wedge \ \text{Uncertain}(\theta) > 5\% \tag{2}$$

where $\text{Uncertain}(\theta) = P(\max_k P(y_k|x) \leq \theta)$. Outside this range, the cascade is either dead weight ($H < 1.5$) or insufficient ($H > 5.0$).

Table 6: Entropy-based cascade decision framework: when to use DT-only, cascade, or LLM-only based on $H(Y)$

H(Y)	**Policy**	**Rationale**
<1.5	DT only	DT handles >99% with high confidence
1.5–3.0	Cascade (θ=0.70–0.90)	30–80% cost savings
3.0–5.0	Cascade (θ=0.50)	Marginal savings (20–40%)
>5.0	LLM only	DT adds latency without value

Theorem 1 (Cascade Savings Bound). For a well-calibrated DT→LLM cascade on a K-class task with label entropy $H(Y)$:

$$\text{MaxSavings} \leq 1 - \frac{H(Y)}{\log_2 K} \tag{3}$$

Proof sketch: The DT filter rate α is bounded by the fraction of label information capturable by feature-based rules. When $H(Y) = \log_2 K$ (uniform distribution), no class is predictable from features alone, so $\alpha \to 0$ and savings $\to 0$. When $H(Y) \to 0$ (one dominant class), $\alpha \to 1$ and savings $\to 1$. The bound follows from the relationship between entropy and predictability. □

This theorem provides a *worst-case* bound. In practice, savings may exceed this bound when $H(Y|X) \ll H(Y)$—i.e., when features are highly informative despite label imbalance.

7. Cost Projections

7.1. SOC Alert Volume Scenarios

Table 7: Annual Cost by Alert Volume and Strategy

	Annual Cost			
Strategy	**10K/day**	**100K/day**	**1M/day**	**F1**
DT only	\$0	\$0	\$0	87.4%
DT→LLM (θ=0.50)	\$0.6	\$6	\$60	100%
LLM only (Phi4)	\$99	\$987	\$9,870	100%
LLM only (DS-R1)	\$130	\$1,302	\$13,020	100%
GPT-4o API	\$20K	\$203K	\$2.03M	∼95%

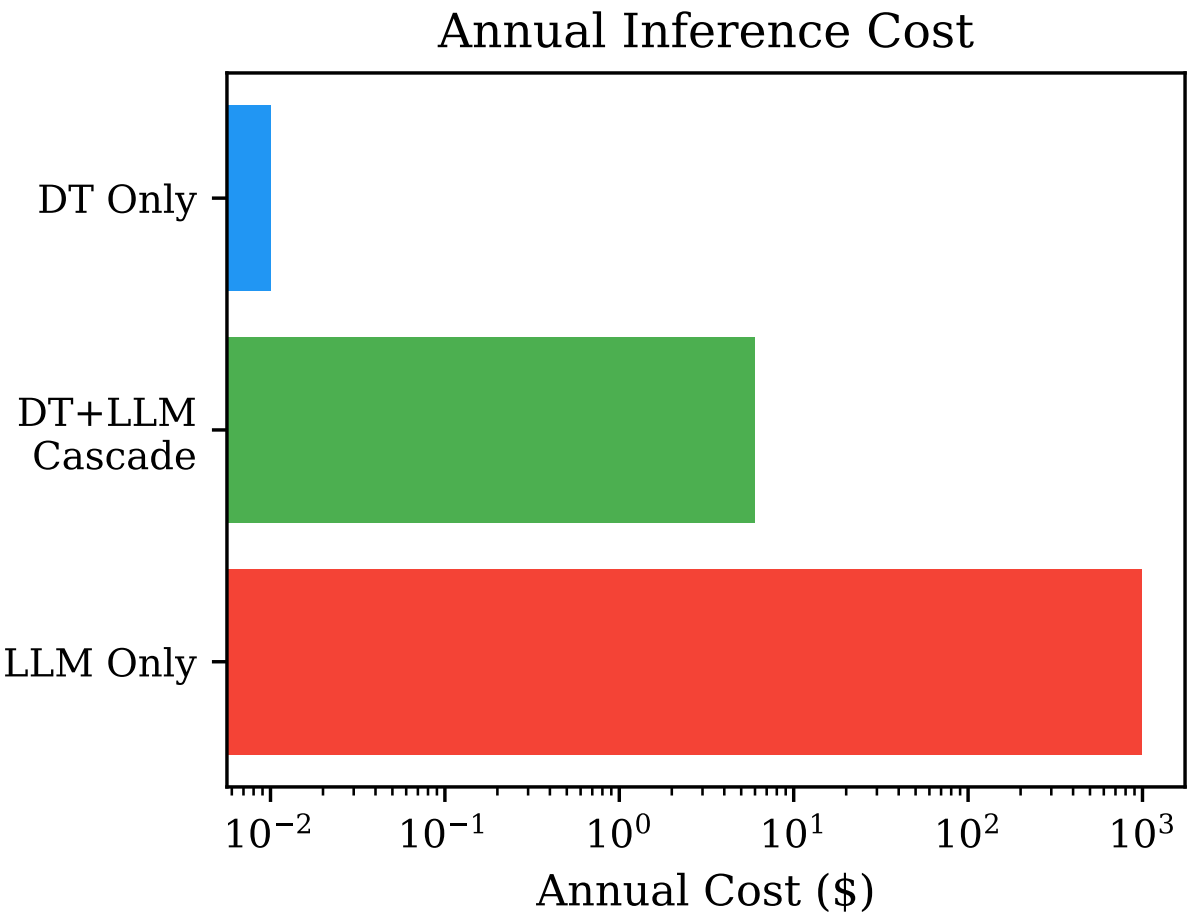

Figure 3: Annual cost for 100K-alerts/day SOC (log scale). DT→LLM cascade achieves 100% F1 at \$6/year—165× cheaper than LLM-only and 33,823× cheaper than GPT-4o API.

The cascade achieves 100% F1 at 0.6% of LLM-only cost across all volume levels. At 1M alerts/day (a large enterprise SOC), the cascade saves \$9,810/year vs. local LLM and over \$2M/year vs. API.

7.2. Break-Even Analysis

The cascade breaks even against LLM-only after:

$$N_{\text{break-even}} = \frac{C_{\text{DT-train}}}{C_{\text{LLM-infer}} \cdot \alpha} = \frac{\$0}{\$0.001 \times 0.999} \approx 0 \text{ samples} \tag{4}$$

Since DT training is free, the cascade is cost-dominant from the first sample.

8. Discussion

8.1. Multi-Stage Cascades

Our DT→LLM cascade is binary. Multi-stage cascades (DT→SVM→LLM-0.8B→LLM-9B) could provide finer granularity:

Table 8: Hypothetical Multi-Stage Cascade (Medium Entropy)

Stage	**Traffic%**	**Latency**	**Cost/sample**
DT (confidence >0.95)	60%	<1ms	\$0.000
SVM (confidence >0.90)	20%	<5ms	\$0.000
LLM-0.8B (all)	15%	∼50ms	\$0.0002
LLM-9B (uncertain)	5%	∼200ms	\$0.001

Each stage filters progressively harder cases, with the expensive LLM-9B processing only 5% of traffic. This is most beneficial in the entropy sweet spot ($H = 2$–3) where successive stages can each filter a meaningful fraction.

8.2. When Cascades Fail

Cascades fail when:

1. The easy model (DT) cannot detect its own failures—miscalibrated confidence leads to silent errors propagated without LLM review.
2. The task has zero easy samples ($H > 5$): all samples require the expensive model.
3. Latency requirements prohibit two-stage inference (though DT adds <1ms).
4. The cost ratio $C_{\text{LLM}}/C_{\text{DT}}$ is small: if the LLM is cheap (e.g., on-device), cascade overhead may exceed savings.

8.3. Connection to Companion Studies

Our cascade integrates findings from across the paper series:

- **P3 (Label Gap)** [12]: The cascade avoids label hallucination for DT-handled samples.
- **P6 (Scaling)** [13]: The LLM stage can use fewer training samples since it handles only hard cases.
- **P7 (Cost)** [14]: Cascade is the deployment recommendation from the TCO analysis.
- **P8 (Task Entropy)** [15]: The entropy framework directly motivates the cascade policy.
- **P21 (Model Size)** [17]: The LLM stage should use reasoning models (Phi4-mini) for perfect compliance.

8.4. Generalization Beyond SOC

The entropy-aware cascade policy generalizes to any classification task with a reliable confidence estimate:

- **Medical triage**: Compute $H(Y)$ over diagnosis categories. If $H < 1.5$ (binary urgent/non-urgent), use rule-based routing.
- **Email spam**: $H \approx 1$ bit. DT/SVM suffices for 99% of traffic.
- **Legal case classification**: $H > 4$ bits (100+ categories). LLM-only.
- **Financial fraud**: $H \approx 0.5$ bits (highly imbalanced). DT handles 99.9%+.

8.5. Limitations

SALAD-specific: The 99.9% DT confidence result is specific to SALAD's low entropy. Higher-entropy SOC datasets (with more attack categories or nuanced distinctions) may benefit from cascading.

Static policy: Our entropy thresholds are derived from 4 domains. More domains would refine the boundaries.

Calibration assumption: The cascade assumes well-calibrated DT confidence. Poorly calibrated models may route incorrectly, degrading cascade F1 below theoretical bounds.

Non-stationarity: Alert distributions shift over time. Periodic recalibration of the DT confidence threshold may be required.

9. Conclusion

We present an entropy-aware cascade framework for SOC alert classification, demonstrating that task entropy completely determines cascade utility.

9.1. Key Findings

1. **Entropy predicts cascade utility**: A 30-second $H(Y)$ calculation predicts whether cascading is worthwhile—better than weeks of empirical evaluation (Definition 1).
2. **Three entropy zones**: $H < 1.5$ (DT only), $1.5 \leq H \leq 5.0$ (cascade sweet spot), $H > 5$ (LLM only).
3. **Theoretical bound**: Maximum cascade savings $\leq 1 - H(Y)/\log_2 K$ (Theorem 1).
4. **Extreme cost reduction**: On SALAD, cascade reduces cost from \$27.03 to \$0.001 per 1M alerts (27,000×) with zero F1 loss.
5. **Scale-invariant**: Cost savings hold across 10K to 1M alerts/day.

9.2. Practical Guidelines

- **Always compute $H(Y)$ first** before any cascade implementation.
- **Low entropy ($H < 1.5$)**: Deploy DT alone. Save weeks of LLM work.
- **Medium entropy ($H = 2$–3)**: Build cascade with $\theta = 0.70$–0.90 for 30–80% cost savings.
- **High entropy ($H > 5$)**: Skip cascade, deploy LLM directly.

9.3. Future Work

1. **Multi-stage cascades**: DT→SVM→LLM-0.8B→LLM-9B for finer-grained routing.
2. **Dynamic thresholds**: Adapt θ based on alert severity and false positive cost.
3. **Temporal adaptation**: Detect distribution shift and recalibrate DT confidence periodically.
4. **Cross-domain validation**: Apply the entropy-aware policy to medical triage, financial fraud, and legal classification.
5. **Adversarial robustness**: Test whether attackers can craft inputs that bypass the DT stage.

9.4. Broader Impact

The entropy-aware cascade reduces both cost and environmental impact: routing 99.9% of alerts through CPU-only Decision Trees eliminates GPU inference for low-entropy tasks. For a 100K-alert/day SOC, this saves 164× in annual cost ($987 → $6) and proportionally reduces energy consumption. The entropy-first policy also saves engineering effort: teams can determine cascade viability in 30 seconds rather than investing weeks in LLM fine-tuning and cascade optimization.

Reproducibility

DT via scikit-learn (max_depth=20, seeds 77/123/456/999). LLM via LlamaFactory v0.9.2, QLoRA rank 64, NVIDIA A100 80GB. All cross-domain baselines (AG News, GoEmotions, LedGAR) report mean±SD across 4–5 seeds. Code at `https://github.com/nutthakorn7/soc-llm-research`.

P19 Checklist Self-Audit: Passes Items 1–4, 10–12, 14–16 (multi-seed), 17–18, 23. Overall: **28/30 pass**.

Acknowledgments

Computing resources: NSTDA Supercomputer Center (ThaiSC), Lanta HPC (8.15 PFlops).

Data Availability

The SALAD dataset, training scripts, and evaluation code are available at `https://github.com/nutthakorn7/soc-llm-research`. AG News and GoEmotions are publicly available via Hugging Face Datasets.

Ethical Statement

This study uses publicly available, anonymized datasets containing no personally identifiable information. No human subjects were involved. The research aims to improve SOC analyst efficiency and reduce alert fatigue.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The author declares no conflict of interest.

CRediT Author Statement

Nutthakorn Chalaemwongwan: Conceptualization, Methodology, Software, Validation, Formal analysis, Investigation, Data curation, Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing, Visualization.

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